

Nielsen Norman Group Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

Evaluator:	John Kenneth F. Boholano
Date:	May 17, 2026
Product:	Student Study Planner and Deadline Tracker
Task:	Task Priority and Add Task View

1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issue

When a user creates a task under a specific subject or reorders its priority, the system updates instantly without visual confirmation. There is no temporary success banner, nor does the task item animate into its new subject group or priority tier. The user is left unsure if the item was successfully saved or filed incorrectly.

Recommendations

Display a quick toast notification at the bottom of the viewport (e.g., "Task successfully added to [Subject Name] under High Priority") and highlight the card with a brief flash animation upon generation.

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issue

The system sorts subjects and priorities using rigid structural codes (e.g., "SUBJ_01", "P-Level 1") rather than standard conventions that match a student's intuitive academic routine (such as course acronyms like "HCI2" or human-readable priority descriptions).

Recommendations

Present fields using friendly, natural language identifiers (e.g., "Subject: Human-Computer Interaction" and "Priority: Urgent"), reinforced with standard real-world color-coding practices.



Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

3

User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action?
- Is *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

If a user selects the wrong subject or gives a task the wrong priority during creation, they cannot hit an "Undo" command on the dashboard. Furthermore, the "Add Task" dialog box lacks a clear "Cancel" or "Go Back" interaction button, forcing the user to commit to an action or refresh the application state entirely.

Recommendations

Put a dedicated, explicit "Cancel" text action link next to the main "Save" button. Provide a quick-revert "Undo" pop-up block whenever tasks are dragged between different subject matrices or priority lanes.

4

Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

Color conventions clash between the subject classifications and the priority indicators. For example, the color Red is used as a category tag for a specific class subject (e.g., IT Elective), but it is also used globally across other views to represent a "High Priority" task. This overlap confuses the user about what the color signifies.

Recommendations

Dedicate a structural design rule where colors are strictly separated. Use high-saturation indicators (Red, Yellow, Green) exclusively for priority tiers. Use neutral pastel badges, custom text labels, or distinct course icons to distinguish academic subjects.



Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

5

Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The "Add Task" entry flow lets users submit a form without tying it to any academic subject or giving it a priority status. This leads to broken or orphaned task cards that float outside the structured grid system, making them incredibly difficult to track.

Recommendations

Make the "Subject" and "Priority" parameters mandatory selections. Keep the primary "Create Task" confirmation button disabled (grayed out) until all core criteria are checked off by the user.

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The users should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in context?

Issues

When trying to choose a task priority inside the creation modal, the system hides the current task counts for each subject. The user has to close out the modal or rely on memory to recall how many high-priority items are already piled up for a specific class code.

Recommendations

Implement a split-view or sliding side-drawer structure for adding tasks instead of a solid overlay. This lets the student quickly reference their active weekly agenda and subject counts in the background while organizing the new item.



Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

7

Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts—hidden from novice users—may speed up the interaction for the expert users such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

The interface forces the user through a deep click-path to organize their workspace. If a student wants to add multiple quick assignments for a specific subject, they must repeatedly open the universal add button, fill the form, select the subject, and choose the priority one by one.

Recommendations

Place an inline quick-add input line (+ Add task to this subject...) directly underneath each subject or priority column header. This allows users to rapidly insert tasks via keyboard commands without opening deep settings windows

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

The main dashboard view is visually cluttered because every individual task card displays a subject tag, a priority label, a deadline indicator, an action icon, and description snippets simultaneously. This causes sensory overload and makes it hard to distinguish critical items.

Recommendations

Apply clean design patterns by grouping task lists under explicit, collapsible subject headings. Rely on a minimalist color indicator dot for priority levels rather than large text pills to let the interface breathe



Heuristic Evaluation Workbook

9

Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

When a required field is missed in the creation window, the system throws a generic error phrase stating "Invalid Input". It does not tell the user if the error is due to a missing task title, a missing subject selection, or an unassigned priority tier

Recommendations

Provide clear, inline red alert text strings directly underneath the specific missing input element (e.g., "Please select an associated subject to continue").

10

Help and Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation. However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

There are no contextual helpers or tooltips to guide users on how the integrated subject and priority filters intersect, leaving first-time students confused on how to best view their overall workload.

Recommendations

Include an optional onboarding information badge (? or i) next to the primary dashboard view controller that explains how to toggle between a Subject-Based View and a Priority-Based View.

